

BODICE AND SKIRT RECEPTION DRESS

This elaborate house dress, designed by American couturier Kate R. Cragmile in 1891, reflects the change in women's fashionable dress from the exaggerated bustle of the 1880s to the rounded hourglass shape of the 1890s. The dress features broad shoulders on leg-of-mutton sleeves, a very narrow waist, and a skirt gently widening to the hemline. The contrasting colours and textures of deep velvet and light-catching silk damask emphasize a tiny waist, while the waistcoat and overdress show the influence of late 18th-century masculine tailoring.

Velvet overdress has a high collar with hidden fastening at front

The emergent leg-of-mutton sleeve, full at the shoulder and tapering into the cuff, grew more exaggerated during first half of 1890s, reaching its fullest dimensions by middle of decade

Waistcoat-style panels over the bodice echo masculine tailoring, yet create impression of a narrow feminine waist

Trained overdress in deep velvet contrasts with the lighter colours of the skirt



SIDE VIEW

IN DETAIL



◁ JABOT

The decorative ruffle of lace at the neck – a jabot – refers back to the late 1600s and draws attention to the width of the upper part of the bodice, while also concealing the dress fastening.